Katrina Ridout
NUTRITION



HEALTHY MUM, HEALTHY BUB.

7 TIPS TO NOURISHING YOU AND YOUR BABY





Congratulations!

So, you have found out the wonderful news that you are carrying a little human. Congratulations! What an exciting time for you and your loved ones!

Whilst you are getting your head around this new fact, pregnancy can also be a daunting time where you suddenly feel completely out of control and that things are moving at a thousand miles per hour. You may have been preparing for this journey for a long time or only since last week, or maybe, it's a big shock to the system….which ever your circumstance, you are most likely feeling vulnerable and totally responsible for the new life inside of you, not wanting to muck things up in anyway, and wanting to do all you can to ensure your baby grows and develops as healthily as they should.

That's why I have put together this neat summary, with all of the key things you need to know about how to nourish your body optimally throughout your pregnancy journey. So grab a refreshing drink and a comfy, quiet spot to focus as I guide you through seven top tips for a healthy baby!

1 Eating Habits

The old ‘eating for two’ idea is a myth. While pregnant women generally need to consume more of most vitamins and minerals, the quantity of food that you consume during pregnancy should not change much. That means that you will need to increase the nutritional quality of the foods you are eating in order to get all the nutrients that you and your baby needs.

How much energy do pregnant women need each day?

Energy requirements for pregnant women vary significantly between women, depending on their level of activity, stage of pregnancy, body composition and pre-pregnancy BMI.

In general if you are at a healthy BMI before becoming pregnant, you need between 9200 kJ (2,200 calories) and 12130 kJ (2,900 calories) a day when expecting. You do not require any extra calories during the first trimester

During the second and third trimesters, women only need an extra 1250kJ (300 calories) per day – even– which is no more than a banana and a small tub of yoghurt.



2 Key Nutrients

Your body is going through a lot of changes and has increased demands when you are growing a baby. Good nutrition during pregnancy is essential. More of certain nutrients are required for your own health as well as for optimal growth and development of your bub. Important nutrients during pregnancy include protein, folate, iron, iodine, Vitamin D, and Vitamin B6.

Protein

Protein is used to grow a baby's tissue, vital organs and brain. It also helps a mother's breast and uterine tissue to grow healthily during pregnancy and it plays a role in your increasing blood supply.

It is recommended that pregnant women consume 75 to 100 grams of protein per day (approximately 2-3 servings of meat or non-meat alternatives such as legumes or nuts (1 serve = approximately 85 g or the size of your palm) Sources may include fully cooked fish or seafood, chicken, lean beef, lamb pork, nuts, tofu.

Folate

Folate is a type of vitamin that helps babies grow normally and develop their nervous system. If a woman doesn't get enough folate before or during pregnancy, it can cause problems for the baby's development. Folate can be found naturally in vegetables, fruits, and beans, or added to foods like cereal and bread. In Australia, all bread flour has to have folic acid in it, which is a type of folate, so eating bread is an easy way to get enough.

Please note however, that most women do not get enough folate from their diet, so as well as eating foods rich in folate, a daily supplement contacting 500mcg (0.5mg) folic acid is recommended to ensure you are getting enough.

*If there is a family history of cleft lip, primal problems or you are taking an anti-epilepsy medication, this dose may need to be greater. Please discuss this with your GP.

Iron

Iron is vital for making red blood cells that transport oxygen in the body. During pregnancy, the growing baby takes iron from the mother, which can increase the risk of pre-term deliveries and low birth weight babies if the mother doesn't get enough iron. Pregnant women need 27 mg of iron a day, 9 mg more than non-pregnant women. While pregnant women lose less iron as they no longer have their menstrual period, this is not enough to meet the needs of the baby. It's important for pregnant women to eat iron-rich foods daily, particularly animal sources that are easily absorbed. Eating vitamin C-rich foods like oranges can aid absorption. Vegetarian women may especially benefit from this. Avoiding caffeine during meals can also help with iron absorption. If diet alone is not enough, a doctor or dietitian can recommend an iron supplement, being cautious of taking too much as high doses can be toxic.

Iodine

Iodine is important for a baby's brain development and helps with growth and development. Not having enough iodine during pregnancy can increase the risk of mental impairment and congenital hypothyroidism for the baby. Eating seafood, seaweed, eggs, meat, and dairy products, as well as using iodized salt, can help. But it's not recommended to increase salt intake too much. Australian bread flour is now fortified with iodine, including gluten-free flour, except for organic and some yeast-free breads. Taking a pregnancy multivitamin that contains 150mcg of iodine per day is also recommended for women who are pregnant, planning to become pregnant, or breastfeeding.

Vitamin D

Vitamin D is essential for your baby's growth and development and your own health during pregnancy. Vitamin D helps to develop of your baby's bones and teeth and low levels can cause muscle weakness and pain in pregnant women.

Fortunately, we get most of our Vitamin D from the sun. Ultraviolet (UV) radiation from the sun produces vitamin D in the skin and is the best source of vitamin D. We can also absorb a small amount from foods like oily fish, egg yolks, margarine and some brands or milk.

You may be vitamin D deficient if you: have darker skin, cover most of your body with clothing, and spend most of your time indoors. If you fit into one of these categories, it is important to discuss this with your GP, who can order a vitamin D test on your blood and suggest a supplement while you are pregnant and breastfeeding.





Calcium

Calcium helps your body regulate fluids, and it helps to build your baby's bones.

Amazingly, your calcium requirements don't increase during pregnancy although the baby has a high requirement for calcium during the third trimester of pregnancy (as it starts to develop and strengthen its bones), a mother's body absorbs calcium much better during pregnancy which means that there is no need for extra intake.

The RDI for non-pregnant women (1000mg per day for women ages 19-50 years, and 1300mg a day for adolescents or those aged over 51) remains unchanged during pregnancy and breastfeeding.

To ensure you are meeting your RDI for dairy in general, foods such as milk, cheese, and yoghurt and calcium-fortified soy milk are excellent dietary sources of calcium.

Vitamin B6

Increased blood volume during pregnancy is the major reason vitamin B6 requirements are higher. Deficiency has been linked with pre-eclampsia or hypertension in pregnancy, excessive vomiting, and it may also impact on infant brain development. However, vitamin B6 is readily available in fortified breakfast cereals, vegetables, fruits and meats, so a balanced diet should easily ensure an adequate intake.

3 Food Sources

The main theme for nutrition during pregnancy is "quality over quantity".

The Australian Guide to Health eating recommends that women consume a variety of food from the 5 core food groups: Grains, Dairy, Meat and alternatives, Fruit and Vegetables.

The following table shows the number of recommended serves for each core food group each day for pregnant women aged 19-50 years:

Recommended average daily number of serves from each of the five food groups*						Additional serves from taller or more active women
Womans Age	**Grain (Cereal) foods**	**Dairy**	**Meat & Alternatives**	**Fruit**	**Vegetables & Legumes**	**Additional serves from the five food groups or discretionary choices**
19 - 50	6	2½	2½	2	5	0 - 2½
51 - 70	4	4	2	2	5	0 - 2½
70 +	3	4	2	2	5	0 - 2
Pregnant	8½	2½	3½	2	5	0 - 2½
Lactating	9	2½	2½	2	7	0 - 2½

**Includes an allowance for unsaturated spreads or oils, nuts or seeds (2 serves (14-20g) per day for women)*



4 Servings



Grains (Bread and cereals)

a standard serve is about 500kJ

- 1 slice bread
- ½ medium bread roll or flat bread/ wrap
- ½ cup cooked rice, pasta, noodles, buckwheat, polenta, semolina, quinoa

*Grain (cereal) foods, mostly wholegrain and / or high cereal fibre varieties



Fruit

a standard serve is about 150g (350kJ)

- 1 medium apple, banana, orange or pear
- 2 small apricots, kiwi fruits or plums
- 1 cup diced or canned fruit (with no added sugar)
- Or only occasionally
- 125ml or ½ cup fruit juice with no added sugar
- 30g dried fruit (1.e. 4 dried apricots, or 1 ½ tablespoons of sultanas)



Vegetables

a standard serve is about 75g (100-350kJ)

- ½ cup cooked green or orange vegetables e.g. broccoli, spinach, carrots, pumpkin
- ½ cup cooked, dried or canned beans, peas, lentils
- 1 cup green leafy or raw salad vegetables
- ½ cup sweet corn
- ½ medium potato or other starchy vegetables (sweet potato, taro or cassava)
- 1 tomato



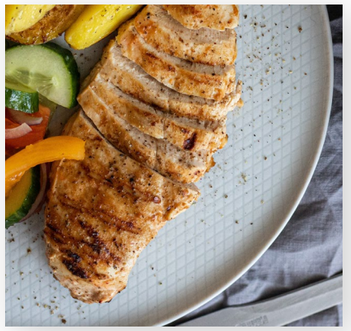
Dairy

a standard serve is about 500-600kJ

- 1 cup (250ml) milk (fresh, UHT long life, reconstituted powdered milk or buttermilk)
- 1 cup (250ml) soy, rice almond or other cereal-based milk, with at least 100mg of added calcium per 100ml
- ¾ cup (200g) yoghurt
- ½ cup evaporated milk
- 2 slices (40g) or 4 x 3 x 2 cm cube (40g) of hard cheese, such as cheddar
- ½ cup ricotta cheese

*choose mostly reduced fat

If you do not eat any foods from this group, try the following foods, which contain about the same amount of calcium as a serve of milk, yogurt, cheese or alternatives (note: the kilojoule content of some of these serves (especially nuts is higher so watch this if trying to maintain a healthy gestational weight gain))



Meat and alternatives

a standard serve is about 500-600kJ

- 65g cooked lean red meats such as beef, lamb, veal, pork, goat or kangaroo (about 90-100g raw)
- 80g cooked lean poultry such as chicken or turkey (100g raw)
- 100g cooked fish fillet (about 115g raw) or one small can of fish
- 2 large (120g) eggs
- 1 cup (150g) cooked or canned legumes / beans such as lentils chickpeas or split peas
- 170g tofu
- 30g nuts, seeds, peanut or almond butter or tahini or other nut or seed paste*
- *only to be used occasionally as a substitute for other foods in the group. Note: this amount for nuts and seeds gives approximately the same amount of energy as the other foods in this group but will provide less protein, iron or zinc. tablespoons of sultanas)



5 Ideal Weight

The amount of weight you gain during pregnancy can affect your own health as well as your baby's health and development. According to the 2009 Institute of Medicine guidelines for gestational weight gain, which are used both internationally and in Australia, the amount of weight women should gain throughout their pregnancy depends on what your weight was before you became pregnant or your 'pre-pregnancy Body Mass Index (BMI)'.

Calculating your BMI

Body mass index (BMI) is the number used to work out what the recommended amount is for you. You can work this out by following the steps below:

Pre-pregnancy weight: ____ kg Height: ____ m (e.g. 165cm is 1.65 m)

$$\textbf{BMI} = \frac{\text{weight}}{\text{height}^2} = \frac{\text{kg}}{\text{m}^2}$$

Now that you've calculated your pre-pregnancy BMI, you can check what your recommended gestational weight gain for pregnancy is below.

Pre-pregnancy BMI	Recommended weight gain over the whole pregnancy	Recommended weight gain per month in the 2nd and 3rd trimester*
less than 18.5kg/m² (Underweight)	12.5kg to 18.0kg	2.0kg to 2.6kg
18.5 – 24.9kg/m² (Normal weight)	11.5kg to 16.0kg	1.5kg to 2.3kg
25.0 - 29.9kg/m² (Overweight) 23.0 - 27.5kg/m² if Asian	7.0kg to 11.5kg	1.0kg to 1.5kg
Above 30.0 kg/m² (Obese) Above 27.5 kg/m² if Asian	7.0kg to 11.5kg	1.0kg to 1.5kg

*Average gain in the first three months is 0.5kg to 2 kg for everyone. Adapted from Institute of Medicine (2009)

The recommendations above are a guide only: there are circumstances where a different weight goal may be recommended by your midwife, doctor or dietitian.

Sounds daunting doesn't it? You may be thinking, it's too late, I'm already overweight or I've already gained more weight than I should have… well, the good news is, no, it's never too late to start making some healthier choices relating to your diet and lifestyle.



6

Maintaining Healthy Weight

Steady, gradual weight gain during pregnancy is normal and important for the health of the mother and baby.

However, gaining too much weight can increase your risk of adverse pregnancy and long-term health outcomes for you and your baby.

Maintaining a healthy weight during pregnancy improves pregnancy outcomes and can also help to improve yours and your baby's health now and in the future.

If you are pregnant, a good approach is to eat to satisfy your appetite and continue to monitor your weight.

If you are overweight or obese, pregnancy is not the time to start dieting or trying to lose weight. Weight gain within the recommended ranges is important to support the growth and development of your baby.

Small changes can make a big difference to both yours and your babies health. If you or your health professional believe you are gaining too much weight or believe you would like some support in managing your weight gain throughout your pregnancy, please talk to an accredited practicing dietitian or your doctor who can support you in your journey to manage your weight in a healthy and sustainable way.

Factors influencing weight gain

- Exercise Habits
- Pregnancy Symptoms
- Eating Habits
- Appetite
- Fluid Retention

Monitoring Your Weight

To help you monitor your weight gain, you can use this pregnancy weight tracker here: BMI less than 25kg/m^2 (healthy weight) & BMI more than 25kg/m^2 (above healthy weight). Just jump on the scales every-one to two weeks at home and plot your progress on the chart. Getting continual feedback about how you are progressing and discussing this with your dietitian, doctor or midwife will help you to see if you are on the right track or need extra support in managing your weight gain.

If you are gaining too much weight...

To control your weight gain, look more closely at what you are eating. Are you meeting all your nutrition needs? Answering these questions will help you to figure out why:

- Are your portion sizes too large?
- Are you eating too many discretionary foods?
- Are you drinking sugary drinks instead of water?
- Are you eating for two?
- Are you including regular exercise each day?

If you are not gaining enough weight...

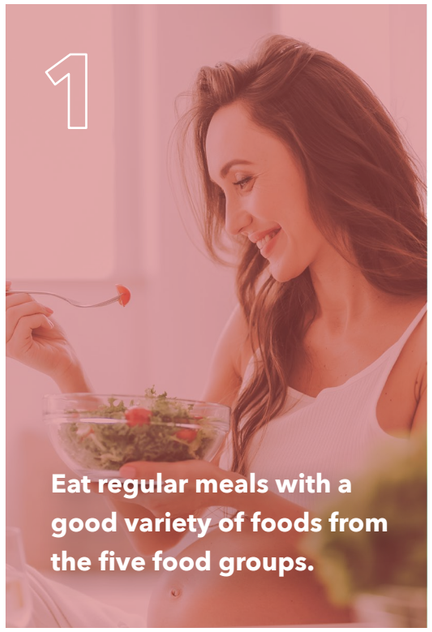
Check that you are:

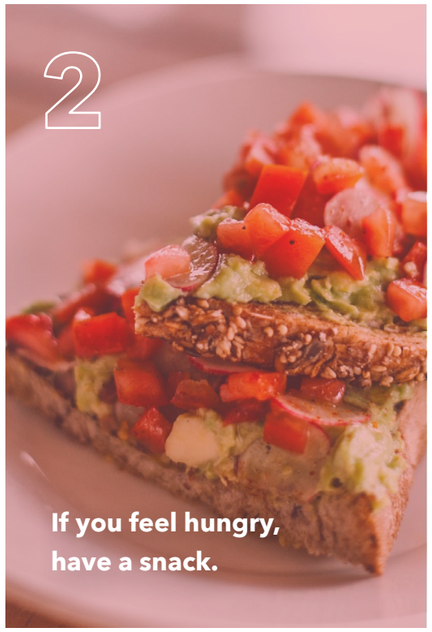
Having three meals a day, and also having in between snacks such as morning tea, afternoon tea and supper.

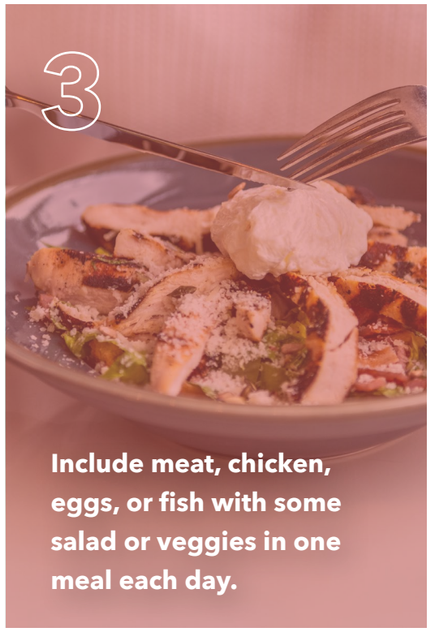
If you are concerned, talk to your dietitian, doctor or midwife about some strategies to help you increase your weight gain.

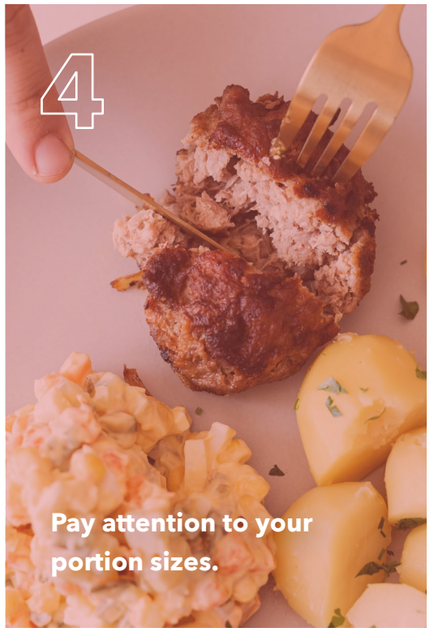


7 Quick Tips!

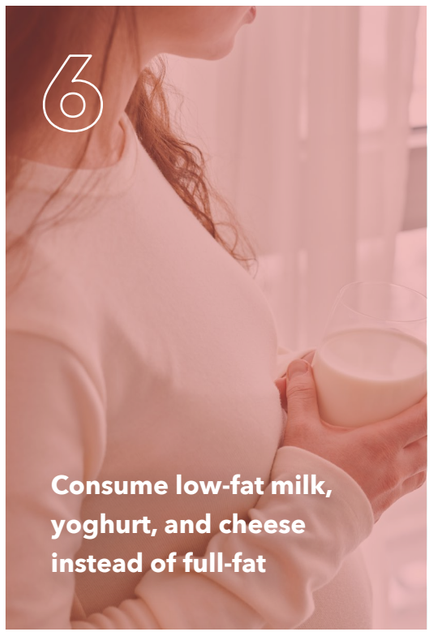

1
Eat regular meals with a good variety of foods from the five food groups.

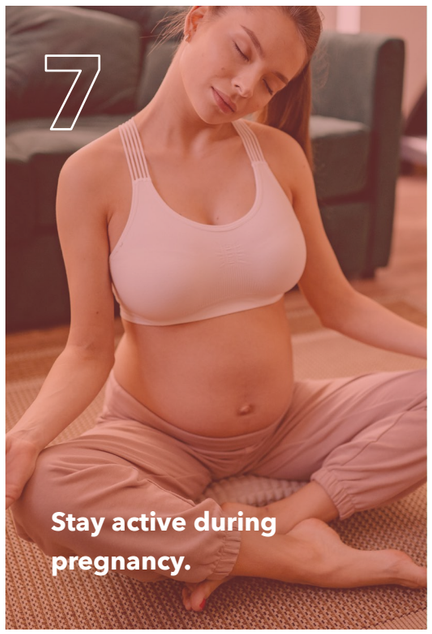

2
If you feel hungry, have a snack.

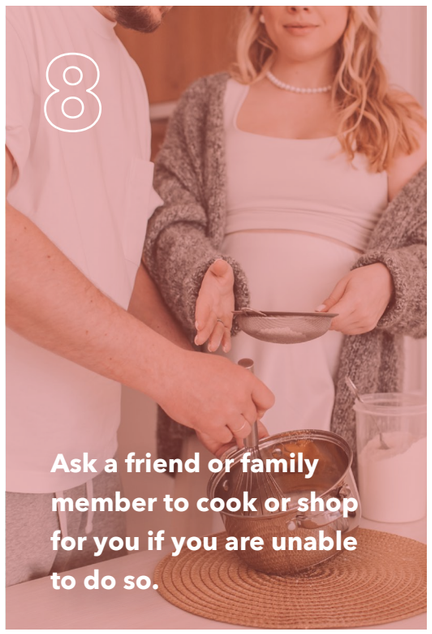

3
Include meat, chicken, eggs, or fish with some salad or veggies in one meal each day.

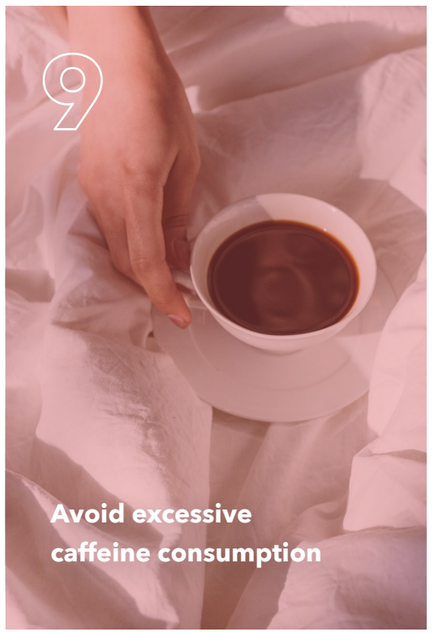

4
Pay attention to your portion sizes.

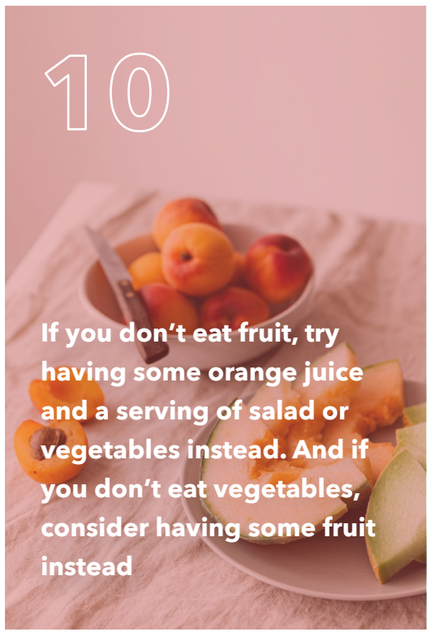

5
Avoid eating too many sugary and fatty foods like cakes, cookies, and soda.


6
Consume low-fat milk, yoghurt, and cheese instead of full-fat


7
Stay active during pregnancy.


8
Ask a friend or family member to cook or shop for you if you are unable to do so.


9
Avoid excessive caffeine consumption


10
If you don’t eat fruit, try having some orange juice and a serving of salad or vegetables instead. And if you don’t eat vegetables, consider having some fruit instead

Healthy Snack Ideas

- Raisin toast
- Fresh fruit
- Dried fruit, nuts and seed mix
- Protein bliss balls
- Low fat or plain yoghurt with fresh fruit
- Muesli bars (for more protein, choose bars with nuts)
- Cheese and crackers
- Milk drinks (i.e. fruit smoothies, milo, milk, Ovaltine - try to choose low fat)
- Grainy bread with, avocado, vegemite, eggs, sardines, baked beans, peanut butter
- A bowl of cereal
- Raw fresh vegetables (celery, capsicum, carrot sticks) with dips (guacamole, hummus)
- Eggs (hard boiled)
- Soups
- Jacket potatoes
- Bran based high fibre cereal with milk
- Bean salad with tomatoes and cucumber
- Banana sandwich
- Ice cream, custard or yoghurt on fruit (try to choose low fat)
- Pasta with cheese and tomato sauce, beans or tuna
- Homemade pizza

Like what you see? Click here to get our complimentary meal plan!



Frequently Asked Questions

What foods should I avoid eating during pregnancy?

During pregnancy, a woman's immune system is lowered, so it is more difficult to fight off infection. Pregnant women have a higher risk of developing food -borne illness caused by listeria, campylobacter and salmonella. Pregnant women are also at risk of developing toxoplasmosis. Infection with these 'bugs' can be dangerous to the health of your baby, and can lead to premature birth, still birth or miscarriage. Therefore, mothers need to be more cautious about their food choices to keep their baby safe.

Tips to avoid food borne illness during pregnancy

1. **Wash your hands before and after preparing food**
2. **Keep your kitchen surfaces clean**
3. **Ensuring kitchen utensils are clean when preparing food**
4. **Do not let uncooked food contaminate cooked food**
5. **Wash fruits and vegetables before eating**
6. **Ensure meats are cooked thoroughly**
7. **Keep pets away from kitchen surfaces**
8. **Store food at correct temperatures**
9. **Do not eat food past its used date**
10. **Wear disposable gloves when gardening**





All about listeria infection

A listeria infection is easily treated with antibiotics, but prevention is best. Some foods are more prone to contamination with listeria than others and should be avoided if you are pregnant. Reduce the risk of listeria infection by eating foods that have been freshly cooked or prepared.

Avoid:

- Buffets, salad bars and sandwich bars
- Meats that are raw or undercooked
- Cold deli meats, packaged / ready to eat meats including cooked cold ready to eat (unless reheated until steaming hot)
- Pre-packaged or pre-prepared fruits and vegetables
- Chilled seafood e.g. raw oysters, sashimi, sushi, and cooked chilled prawns or smoked salmon
- Coft cheese like brie, camembert, fetta and ricotta (safe if cooked and hot)
- Unpasteurised milk products and juices
- Refrigerated pate, meat spreads or smoked seafood
- Raw or undercooked eggs
- Raw sprouts
- Soft serve ice cream

Please Note Listeria is killed by cooking, so make sure that when you reheat food, it is very hot. In additiona, salmonella is a cause of food poisoning that can trigger miscarriage. The most likely sources of salmonella are raw eggs and undercooked meat and poultry.

What vitamins do I need to take for pregnancy?

Even where choosing nutrition foods, it can be difficult to get enough of all the essential nutrients you need from your diet alone. It is therefore recommended that all women who are pregnant take a pregnancy multivitamin supplement each day in addition to a healthy diet. This will help to ensure you are getting enough of the key nutrients for your baby's development.

What types of fish are safe to eat during pregnancy?

Eating fish once or twice a week during your pregnancy is a great aim as it is high in protein and high in omega-3 essential fatty acids which your body and baby can benefit from during pregnancy. It's important however, that you limit your consumption of some specific fish types that are high in mercury as these fish may affect the developing nervous system of unborn babies and infants.

The types of fish that you need to limit include:

- Shark (flake), broadbill, marlin, and sword fish should be eaten only once per fortnight with no other fish that fortnight
- Orange roughy (sea perch) and catfish should be eaten no more than once per week, with no other fish that week
- Any other fish not mentioned above may be eaten safely two to three times per week.

Pregnant women are encouraged to eat 150g fish twice a week, but to avoid exposing your unborn child to excessive mercury. Choose fish like sardines, salmon, herring and trout. They pack a mean omega-3 punch, but are low risk for mercury.

Can I drink alcohol when I am pregnant?

There is no known safe level of alcohol consumption for women who are pregnant. Consuming alcohol during pregnancy increases the risk of miscarriage, low birth weight, congenital deformities and effects on the baby's intelligence. The Australian guidelines to reduce health risks from drinking alcohol recommend that the safest option for pregnant women is not to drink alcohol at all.

If you find it difficult to decrease or stop drinking alcohol during pregnancy, talk to your doctor or midwife, your local community health services, or an alcohol and other drug helpline in your state or territory.





Can I drink coffee?

There are a number of good reasons backed by science for why consuming caffeine is a bad idea when you are pregnant. Firstly, caffeine is a stimulant. It increases your blood pressure and heart rate, both of which can be dangerous to you and your baby. It is also a diuretic, meaning it increases the amount of times you need to urinate and as a result, can lead to dehydration. Last but not least, caffeine crosses the placenta to your baby, so although you may be able to handle the amounts of caffeine you feed your body, your baby cannot metabolise the caffeine yet, and therefore any amount of caffeine can affect your baby's development, sleep patterns and movement patterns. Therefore, the bottom line is the less caffeine you consume, the better.

Remember that caffeine is found in more than just coffee. It is also found in tea, some soft drinks, energy drinks and chocolate so be aware of what you consume.

Remember Caffeine is found in more than just coffee. It is also found in tea, some soft drinks, energy drinks and chocolate so be aware of what you consume.

What about food cravings?

If you find you're craving certain foods, there is usually no reason why you can't indulge a little – but pregnancy isn't an excuse to go overboard on treats! Contrary to popular belief, food cravings are not an indication of what your body needs. Choose nutrient-dense foods like fresh and dried fruit, nuts, frozen yoghurt and lean protein to counter the cravings. Limit foods containing empty calories, like soft drink, sweets and fried foods. Pregnancy is a time to make every mouthful count and nutrient-rich foods will benefit your baby and keep you healthy.

Other nutritional concerns

During pregnancy, there are substances that you need to eliminate that can cause harm to your baby. These include tobacco smoke, drug use and alcohol.



A note from Kat

It's common to feel a range of emotions during pregnancy, from excitement and joy to worry and anxiety. But no matter what you're feeling, rest assured that you're not alone. Many expectant parents experience a variety of emotions during this time, as they prepare for the arrival of a new member of the family.

By reading this guide, you're already on the right track to taking the best possible care of yourself and your baby. This guide offers scientifically sound nutritional advice from an experienced and qualified dietician with over 12 years of university and post-graduate education, including 8 years of experience in the field of nutrition and 4 years specifically in the field of prenatal nutrition. This means you can trust that the information you're receiving is reliable and up-to-date.

Nutrition plays a crucial role in pregnancy, as what you eat can impact not only your own health but also the health of your baby and even the health of future generations. Pregnancy is a unique opportunity for you to reset your own health and the health of your family, and this guide will help you make the most of it. By following the advice presented here, you'll be well on your way to giving your baby a lifetime of good health.

So, don't underestimate the importance of nutrition during pregnancy. Take advantage of this opportunity to make positive changes for yourself and your family's health, and trust that you're making the best possible choices for your baby's future.

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